



AN ELDERLY COUPLE WITH A SISTER; (BELOW) INMATES AT THE LITTLE SISTERS OF THE POOR HOME

grounds, the freshly painted two-storied buildings and the mirror-clean floors make the interiors look more like a sophisticated guesthouse than a home for the poor. There is, also, no overt religiosity. "Everything runs on donations," says Mother Jean. "Hindus are our biggest donors. We have a mixed lot of 150 residents here, the oldest being 95. Though we have a chapel inside, Hindus and Muslims are free to practice their religions. All we need is clear proof that the prospective resident is poor and has nobody to look after him or her."

Saint Jeanne was born in 1792 to a sailor father in Brittany whom she lost when she was only four. Young Jeanne Jugan devoted her life to God and serving the poor. On one instance, during

English nationals each and one Maltese, ventured out from the island of Malta. Arriving here, they set up a small home and moved from home to home to serve the needy. Those days there was no money and they used bullock carts or walked long stretches on foot. Every day, the sisters used to pray for a miracle which could give them some strength to fight the acute poverty and give them hope to survive the next day. As if like a bolt from the blue, a racehorse from the building opposite to theirs strayed into the home's compound. Its master came looking for it and seeing the acute distress of the sisters offered to donate the horse to them for transport. That was what the sisters considered a miracle.

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balconies in the shining mosaic-floored buildings resound to the sound of blaring television sets and radios. In fact, the old men and women seem to be a happy lot. On Diwali morning, the inmates lounging on the balconies and basking in the glory of reflected sainthood, were happily listening to Hindi music on television. The clean rooms, the amenities and the general air of bonhomie indicate nothing of the stench that poverty is associated with. The sprawling

her daily rounds asking for alms for the poor and aged, a man slapped her. The young woman, Gandhi-like, offered her other cheek, saying: "For this cheek, you will have to donate something for the poor." In 1882, three years after Jeanne had died leaving behind a structured Order of 2,400 sisters across Europe, a rescue call arrived from India's then capital, Calcutta, asking for missionary help from the church. Five sisters, comprising two French and

Father Jose, who has spent 20 years with the Missionaries of Charity, feels there are hardly any similarities between the Little Sisters and Teresa's Order. "I had been with the Mother and I know she was very meticulous. Her watchword was strength through suffering. I have seen how much the Missionaries of Charity sisters can work under extreme conditions. But the Little Sisters, not any less, look after only the aged and poor. They are more focused that way. The ambit of work cannot be compared; Mother Teresa's Charity is truly international and by its sheer nature, somewhat private. You cannot expect the Charity's sisters to be on call and be social and talk to the press all the time. They are far too busy. And Mother herself was against public glare though she did get her maximum share."

At the Little Sisters complex, an old man neatly folds tie after tie and packs them in a suitcase. The busy man looks up and says with a smile, "You see, it's my birthday tomorrow. I am trying to choose which tie to wear."

How old are you?

"Ninety five... and you?" By the time, Mother Jean begins her introductions, he had already made his choice. ■



“What you might want to know is that Mother Teresa herself stayed at the Little Sisters of the Poor when she left the Loreto nunnery and had no place to live in Kolkata.”

MOTHER JEAN, Mother Superior, Little Sisters of the Poor